

Creating a grammar

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Theory of Compilation
Laboratory 2

Types of parsers

- LL parsers
 - JavaCup
 - ANTLR
- LR parsers
 - flex/yacc (C language)
 - SLY (Python)
 - PLY (Python)

Grammar transformations

Necessary transformation for LL and LR grammars

- LL parsers
 - left recursion removal
 - left factorization
- LR parsers
 - Grammar augmentation with a new start symbol and production $\langle new_start_symbol \rangle \rightarrow \langle old_start_symbol \rangle$

Example

Grammar of arithmetic expressions

```
<expr> -> <expr> '+' <term>
        | <expr> '-' <term>
        | <term>

<term> -> <term> '*' <factor>
        | <term> '/' <factor>
        | <factor>

<factor> -> '(' <expr> ')'
          | id
```

Grammar transformations for ANTLR

- In practice, left recursion removal is not performed
- Grammar is specified in EBNF (extended BNF) instead of BNF

Example

```
<expr> -> <term> (( '+' | '-' ) <term>)*
```

```
<term> -> <factor> (( '*' | '/' ) <factor>)*
```

```
<factor> -> '(' <expr> ')'  
          | id
```

Grammar transformations for JavaCup

- Explicit left recursion removal

Example

- Grammar of arithmetic expressions after left recursion removal

```
<expr> -> <term> <exprp>
```

```
<exprp> -> '+' <term> <exprp>  
         | '-' <term> <exprp>
```

```
<term> -> <factor> <termp>
```

```
<termp> -> '*' <factor> <termp>  
         | '/' <factor> <termp>
```

```
<factor> -> '(' <expr> ')'  
         | id
```

Grammar transformations for SLY or PLY

Example

- Original unambiguous grammar of arithmetic expressions can be used
- But it makes parser table and parse tree larger than necessary
- It also slows down parsing

```
<expr> -> <expr> '+' <term>
        | <expr> '-' <term>
        | <term>

<term> -> <term> '*' <factor>
        | <term> '/' <factor>
        | <factor>

<factor> -> '(' <expr> ')'
          | id
```

Grammar transformations for SLY or PLY

Example

- A better way: use simple, ambiguous grammar of arithmetic expressions and resolve conflicts explicitly by specifying precedence and associativity of operators
- Operators with lower priority come first in the precedence list

```
precedence = (  
    ...  
    ("left", '+', '-'),  
    ("left", '*', '/'),  
    ...  
)  
...  
<expr> -> <expr> '+' <expr>  
          | <expr> '-' <expr>  
          | <expr> '*' <expr>  
          | <expr> '/' <expr>  
          | '(' <expr> ')'  
          | id
```

Ambiguity - source of conflicts

- Ambiguous grammars cannot be LR and cause conflicts in parser tables

Example - matrix specification

```
outerlist -> outerlist innerlist
outerlist -> innerlist
innerlist -> innerlist elem
innerlist -> elem
```

- Language modification by introduction of separators between vectors (;) and between vector elements (,)
- Language modification enables grammar modification into unambiguous grammar

```
outerlist -> outerlist ; innerlist
outerlist -> innerlist
innerlist -> innerlist , elem
innerlist -> elem
```

Dangling else conflict

Source of shift-reduce conflict

```
if_stmt : IF '(' expr ')' stmt  
        | IF '(' expr ')' stmt ELSE stmt
```

- Shifting preferred over reduce
- Solution - we resolve conflict by choosing shift over reduce:

```
precedence = (  
    ("nonassoc", 'IFX'),  
    ("nonassoc", 'ELSE'),  
)  
  
...  
  
if_stmt : IF '(' expr ')' stmt %prec IFX  
        | IF '(' expr ')' stmt ELSE stmt
```

LR grammar that is not LALR

```
def : param_spec return_spec ','  
  
param_spec : type  
           | name_list ':' type  
  
return_spec : type  
            | name ':' type  
  
type : ID  
  
name : ID  
  
name_list : name  
          | name ',' name_list
```

LR grammar

LR grammar that is LALR

```
def : param_spec return_spec ','  
  
param_spec : type  
           | name_list ':' type  
  
return_spec : type  
            | ID ':' type  
  
type : ID  
  
name : ID  
  
name_list : name  
          | name ',' name_list
```

bison spec.y -Wcex/-Wcounterexamples

Recursion in LR grammar

Left recursion

```
exprseq : expr  
        | exprseq ',' expr
```

- parsing a sequence of any number of elements requires only bounded stack space
- a list should be reversed

Right recursion

```
exprseq : expr  
        | expr ',' exprseq
```

- parsing a sequence of any number of elements requires linear stack space
- adding element to a list is straightforward

References

- ① <https://sly.readthedocs.io/en/latest/sly.html>,
Sect. Writing a Parser
- ② <http://www.dabeaz.com/ply/ply.html>, Sect. 6
- ③ <https://www.gnu.org/software/bison/manual/bison.pdf>